2

Eight Five Five

Farlowe unscrewed his silencer, holstered his pistol, and turned to Phillips, who scanned the scene around him.

"Eight hundred heavy, times two," Phillips said into his Bluetooth headset.

Farlowe studied his handiwork. A clean entry wound on Jarvis' forehead only hinted at the horrors that were once the back of his skull.

"Heavy hangs the head that wears the crown," he muttered under his breath as he listened in on Phillips. Farlowe could see Devra's body laying on its side, partially obscured by shadows.

Phillips turned to him. "Cleaners are en route. Two minutes."

"Shoulda been center-mass. We wouldn't need so many sponges," Farlowe said.

"That's the way it came in," Phillips replied as he moved

toward Devra's corpse.

Farlowe surveyed his surroundings. He didn't see anybody, but he did hear a voice. Female, Swiss-German accent. Frantic.

Phillips grunted and stepped over to Devra. Blood had sprayed onto the statue behind her. Two head-shots, just like the mission request. But something was wrong.

"She's calling the police," Farlowe said.

"What?" Phillips was distracted, which is precisely what he shouldn't have been at this moment.

Farlowe moved closer to Phillips. "I can understand what she's saying. She's calling the police."

"It's not her." Phillips rolled the body at his feet onto its back.

Phillips looked at Farlowe as a dark panel van pulled up next to them. Three cleaners, all in their late twenties, two men and one woman, quickly jumped out of the van and moved to the bodies.

"It's not Bogdanovich... What the hell?"

If Farlowe was surprised by this news, his years of training and fieldwork had taught him how to hide it.

Farlowe reached for his weapon and started to screw back on the silencer.

"I'll take care of the witness."

"No. We assumed somebody would see this. We're in a very public place."

"So now what?" Farlowe asked Phillips.

"Now we clean up this mess and get the hell out of here. Now Bogdanovich is on the run. So now you find her. I want no open communications. You talk to nobody but me. I'll give you your next move when I know what it is. Now you go."

Suddenly, they both were bathed in green light. Like a plasma. Farlowe looked for a source. There wasn't one. Still, he kept looking. It was coming from Jarvis' corpse. Enveloping them.

"What the..."

Phillips grabbed hold of Farlowe's arm and pulled him backwards as the cleaning crew covered their eyes.

"Everyone get back! It's XM!" Phillips yelled, but to Farlowe, it was like listening to someone from below the surface of water. Distorted. Muffled.

Farlowe had a sense of falling backwards as his eyes locked onto the glowing plasma floating near him. It was assembling itself, like a mist with intelligence. Farlowe heard a deafening hiss. It sounded like something he had heard many times before. The final exhale. A death rattle. Then, the mist drifted towards the base of the Escher statue and was sucked into the earth.

"Farlowe! Farlowe!"

He would never know what happened for the next few seconds. Farlowe tried to force his thoughts into focus, and when he did, everybody was gone. He was alone in front of the statue. His pistol and silencer were missing.

"Farlowe!"

The agent looked down at his hands. The woman cleaner was swabbing his hands with disinfectant, removing gunshot residue. The cleaner next to her was dropping his pistol and silencer into a large plastic bag.

"You with us? Or are you with someone else?" Phillips asked Farlowe.

"Completely with you, sir," Farlowe lied. He realized that he was momentarily out. He didn't remember them taking his

gun or starting on his hands.

"We got clear, but you were in the stuff for a few seconds."

"Felt like longer," Farlowe said, studying Phillips. "I'm good."

Phillips handed his Glock 31 chambered with .357 SIG to Farlowe.

"You'd better be."

An hour later, Farlowe was driving south. There was little hope that he would overtake Bogdanovich, but he'd catch up with her sooner or later. If she was still on the train, there were only so many places she could go. He just had no idea what he was going to do when he did catch up with her. The Glock in his waistband told him what Phillips had in mind, but Farlowe wasn't so sure.

Instead, he felt a sense of purpose. He just didn't know what it was yet.

Farlowe reached for his phone. Not in his jacket. The cleaners had taken that, too. He found this simultaneously annoying and liberating. The car he was driving was a company vehicle, so Phillips could track him and find him when he needed to, Farlowe thought to himself as he drove into the night.

The blur of thoughts that had been ripping through his mind had been reduced to focusing on a never ending dark horizon. The vanishing point. Still, things were coming into focus. A new clarity. He was connecting ideas and thoughts and facts and experience into an emerging pattern of what had happened in Zurich, and who might have been behind it. And to Farlowe, none of it looked good.

Either someone botched the order, or Devra had somehow been tipped off to what was coming and was able to make a switch. Or she had gotten very lucky.

Uncertainty was something he always tried to avoid in his career. But now Farlowe had the sense that this was precisely where he found himself. He was in the dead center of swirling chaos.

Maybe it was the XM that had hit him earlier that had him thinking this way. Farlowe realized that he felt different. He didn't know why. But he did know that nothing would ever be the same again. And something inside of him was happy about this.

And for reasons he couldn't yet comprehend, Farlowe also knew he was heading in the right direction. Toward Devra. Toward the dark horizon and the woman who had vanished.

A bus with wings. That is what flying has become, 855 thought to himself as he dealt cards onto the fold-down drink tray in front of him.

His job was full of little indignities – people begging for their lives. Others trying to kill him. The isolation. The lack of any steady personal relationship. The blood. His life was constant movement, like that of a shark who can never stop swimming. Actually, now that he thought about it, he liked all those things. But damn it all when he had to fly coach. Still, it was the luck of the cards.

He turned the deck over and pulled out the kings and jacks, setting the rest of the cards aside.

He looked at the eight face cards. For each, he had a story – a story that he had rehearsed so many times and played so many times that each was a part of him. He had spent so much of his life telling the detailed lies of each of the painted men in front of him that he had given up trying to keep them straight from his own life before the agency.

Now, each was a unique cover identity. Kings were married men. Jacks single. Clubs were workaday Joes. Spades: technology. Diamonds: wealth, of course. And hearts: family and romance.

He tried to remember how many times he had stared at these cards before. Too many to count. But they provided the chaos – the random chance that he relied on, and that had served him well up until now.

That was the thing about his job that people didn't understand, if he would have ever been allowed to explain it to them. Which he wouldn't. This line of work was about detail and procedure. Like the pilots who currently had his life in their hands, he had his pre-flight checklist. And like the pilots, he followed it religiously.

But he had also learned that ordered routine eventually breeds complacency and carelessness, and that patterns were how he tracked his victims. So he came up with the cards. Eight chances to be someone else each time he started a new hunt.

"Is it a trick?" asked the teenage girl seated next to him. She was about fourteen. Slightly overweight. He could hear Katy Perry coming from her headphones as he turned to her.

"No. Pick a number between one and eight," he said as he studied her. He hadn't killed anyone her age in months. She smiled.

"Five," she said.

"Right. Five it is." He turned the cards over and scrambled them, then dealt them face up, counting as he did so.

"One, two, three, four and five. The king of diamonds."

"What does that mean?" she asked.

"I have no idea. Here, you try it." He gathered up the cards, and as he scrambled them, slipped a folded twenty dollar bill

that he had casually palmed from his pocket under the fourth card.

"I'll say a number. You deal."

"Okay."

"What's your name?"

"Sandra," she said.

"Nice to fly with you, Sandra. Four."

She dealt the cards. "One, two, three..."

On the fourth card, she stopped.

"Twenty." She smiled at him. "I thought you said this wasn't a trick."

"I lied."

"Can I keep this?"

"Not the cards. Those are mine. And since that is all I handed you, I really have no claim to anything else you may have found."

"Is this like a 'pay it forward' thing? I bet you probably surprise a lot of people."

"That I do," he said, as he got up and headed for the bathroom.

Sandra shrugged, then stuffed the twenty into her purse and turned Katy Perry back up.

In the airplane lavatory, 855 looked into the mirror, staring at his face. Still handsome, but now with deep lines forming around his eyes and on his forehead. Green eyes, but he could change those when needed with contacts. He wasn't sure what his real hair color was anymore. For now, it was brown, and just starting to go grey. Early forties but keeping it together.

He opened the hidden area in the lining of his jacket, and pulled out a small envelope labeled "King of Diamonds." Inside were a passport, a health insurance card, and three credit

cards, all identifying him as Karl Ameston. He tucked them into his wallet, removing the previous ones in the process. He washed his hands, and then wrapped the old passport and cards thoroughly with a paper towel. Satisfied, he tossed the bundle into the waste bin.

As he sat back in his seat, Sandra turned to him.

"I forgot to say 'thanks' and ask your name."

"You're welcome. And Karl," he said.

Christie was being extremely polite. He hadn't asked Devra for any details when he picked her up at the train station. Hadn't prodded for information on the car ride to the small pub they now found themselves in. Even now, he was seemingly content to drink his beer and make small talk.

"You see all the graffiti on the side of the building on the way in? That's been there for over twenty years."

Devra looked up from her drink and studied Dr. Christie Novosel, one of the best chemical engineers she had ever worked with. He was a big man, broad shouldered and with glasses as thick as his neck. His moustache was grey and full and bounced around the top of his lip with each word he spoke.

"Hmmm..."

"In most places, it would be a sign of neglect. But here, it is a sign of pride. All around Zagreb. When the wall came down, the first signs of revolt were seen on the sides of buildings that had been sprayed with a rattle can. So it stays. And is transformed. From vandalism into an expression of freedom."

Christie looked around the room, then back at Devra.

"They call it 'street art' now. Some of the most famous sell their works for millions. It's gone mainstream," Devra said.

"Well then, all I need is a sledgehammer and some nice

frames and my retirement is assured," Christie laughed.

Devra smiled back at him. He's doing well, she thought. It must be eating him up inside not to ask her the obvious question.

"How about your legacy, Christie? What if I could help with that?" Devra said.

Suddenly, Christie's face seemed to change. His expression became serious. Focused. He'd been waiting for this, and Devra had given him his opening. He intended to make the best of it.

"So this is about CERN? What you have been up to and why do you call me out of the blue for the first time in three years, and two hours later we sit together having a beer? How much can you tell me? Well, how much are you willing to tell me?"

Devra leaned back in her chair and studied the room. Nobody else seemed interested in them. She had intentionally picked a booth in the corner and was seated so she could keep an eye on the door.

"It's called Niantic. Named after some ship that's buried under San Francisco. The NIA names all their projects after shipwrecks. That should have been my first clue." Devra exhaled, seemingly for the first time in days.

Christie raised his beer and took a long swig, indicating that he had no intention of interrupting her.

"We had been studying the effects of a substance we call Exotic Matter. I believe that it has an extra-dimensional component that, as of yet, I can't explain. We saw it first on the sub-atomic scale, but now... it flows into our... reality. And it's being crafted..."

"Crafted?"

"Like DNA, it's a building block that can be used to create–"

Christie cut her off. "DNA creates life, Devra," he said with a blank look on his face.

"Right now the NIA are using it to create weapons. For the moment, they only seem able to affect other XM constructs," Devra replied.

"But that is not where you think this will end, do you?" asked Christie. The seriousness of what they were talking about was washing over him, and Devra could see it on his face. "That is why you are here now?"

Devra nodded as she reached out and touched Christie's hand. "That and the fact they tried to kill me," she said.

Christie's eyes widened.

"What? When?"

"Hours ago. In Zurich."

"So you are on the run?" Christie sputtered.

Devra nodded.

"And you need my help, obviously... anything... just tell me and if I have it, it is yours."

His voice was rising. Adrenaline was kicking in for the big man, and he was becoming more animated. Devra gestured towards him and Christie composed himself.

"Anything," he said.

Devra squared herself. From the looks of it, she had her first real ally.

"I'm going to need your expertise, Christie. I'm going to fight fire with fire. You know more than anyone else on the planet about converting raw materials into useable forms. And that's what I'm going to do with XM."